

DIGITALAIKART

THE SCAM-PROOF FAMILY HANDBOOK

*Protect your parents, your money and yourself
from India's digital fraud epidemic*

The 12 scams hitting Indian families right now, decoded

The 45-minute Family Shield setup you can do tonight

The first-60-minutes protocol that can freeze stolen money

The RBI rules that decide who bears the loss

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START HERE

One rule stops 9 out of 10 scams

Read this page before anything else. It is the whole handbook in one line.

The one rule

No real bank, police officer, customs official, courier company or government agency will ever ask you to move money to a new account, share an OTP, or stay on a video call to "verify" your identity. The moment anyone asks for any of these, you are being scammed. Hang up. Nothing bad will happen to you for hanging up.

Everything in this handbook serves that one rule. Scammers win by making you act before you think, and they lose the moment you pause. This book gives you and your family four things:

- **A map of the 12 scams** that are actually draining Indian families in 2026, with the exact tells that expose each one.
- **The 45-minute Family Shield setup** - official, free settings from UIDAI, the Department of Telecommunications, TRAI and your bank that close the most common doors.
- **The first-60-minutes protocol** - the 1930 helpline and cybercrime.gov.in steps that let banks freeze stolen money before it vanishes.
- **The RBI rules** that decide who bears the loss when fraud happens - and how to report so the law stands on your side.

How to use it: read Part 3 with your family tonight. Do Part 5 yourself, then do it again on your parents' phones. Print the Emergency Action Card in Part 9 and put it on the fridge. Keep the PDF on your phone.

Every fact, number, helpline and process in this book was verified against official sources - the Reserve Bank of India, the Ministry of Home Affairs, UIDAI, the Department of Telecommunications, TRAI and cybercrime.gov.in - as of 24 September 2026. Sources are listed on the final page.

PART 1

The threat is not coming. It is here.

The numbers every Indian family should know before they think 'this can't happen to us'.

Rs. 22,845 Cr

lost by Indians to cyber fraud in 2024 alone - a 206% jump over 2023 (data tabled in Parliament, July 2025)

Rs. 3,000 Cr

extorted through 'digital arrest' scams, per the MHA-CBI report to the Supreme Court

2.97 lakh

digital-arrest complaints registered from 2022 to May 2026

In 2024, over 22 lakh cybercrime incidents were reported in India, and 85% of them were online financial fraud. The Supreme Court took up the digital-arrest epidemic on its own motion in October 2025 after a 73-year-old Ambala woman wrote to the Chief Justice describing how

fraudsters posing as CBI officials extorted over Rs. 1 crore from her using fake court orders with forged signatures. Since then the Court has passed a series of orders pressing the CBI, RBI, banks and telecom authorities to respond, and the CBI's Operation Chakra-VI ran searches at 89 locations across 20 States in September 2026.

If it helps to know that even sharp people fall, it does. Among the recorded victims: a Supreme Court advocate, an engineering professor, retired professionals, homemakers, and doctors. Here is what the biggest cases looked like:

Victim	What happened	Loss
NRI doctor couple, Delhi	Held under 'digital arrest' on video calls for over two weeks; accused of money laundering by fake telecom-police team	Rs. 14.85 Cr
Businessman, 81, Belagavi	A fake CBI caller linked him to a famous fugitive; an 'RBI official' made him break fixed deposits over six weeks; found by his son at Ugadi	Rs. 15.45 Cr
Homemaker, Gurugram	Told a parcel in her name held drugs for Beijing; kept under 24/7 Skype surveillance for five days; recovered only about Rs. 1 Cr of it a year later	Rs. 5.85 Cr
Retiree, Rajasthan	Kept under 'digital custody' for three months, extorted 42 times via 42 transactions	Rs. 7.67 Cr

There is one encouraging number in all this. Digital-arrest complaints on the national cybercrime portal went from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,239 in 2025, and 16,377 in the first half of 2026. Nothing about the fraudsters improved - awareness did. Families that know the tells simply hang up. That is exactly what this handbook is for.

PART 2

Every scam is four tricks wearing a costume

Learn the four levers once, and you will recognise new scams nobody has invented yet.

Fraudsters do not need to hack your bank. They need to hijack your decision-making for twenty minutes. Every scam in Part 3 - and every one that will be invented next year - pulls the same four levers:

The lever	How it feels	The counter
AUTHORITY	A police officer, a CBI official, an RBI manager, a bank verification officer - with badge numbers, case numbers, official-looking documents	Real authority arrives in writing, on numbers you can verify. No agency in India interrogates on a video call
FEAR + URGENCY	'Your account will be blocked in 30 minutes', 'a warrant has been issued', 'act now or your family...'	Urgency is the scammer's tool. Anything real can wait one hour and one phone call to your family
ISOLATION	'This is a confidential case, do not tell your family or a lawyer', 'stay on the line', 'stay in your room with the camera on'	Secrecy is the single brightest red flag in this book. Real processes are never secret

The lever	How it feels	The counter
HOPE	A part-time job paying Rs. 5,000 a day, guaranteed 3% daily returns, a refund you weren't expecting	If it pays more than a job should for doing almost nothing, the work is your money

Two habits beat all four levers together. The **pause**: no money moves without ten minutes and one verification call. The **call-out**: you tell one family member about any call that scared you, the moment it happens. Scammers structure their entire script around preventing exactly these two things.

PART 3

The 12 scams every Indian family must know

How each one starts, the tell that gives it away, and exactly what to do.

SCAM 01

Digital arrest - the one that takes crores

How it starts. A caller claims to be from FedEx, customs, the police, the CBI or the Enforcement Directorate. A parcel in your name has been seized with drugs, passports or credit cards; or your SIM card was 'used in a money-laundering case'. The call is transferred to a 'police officer' on WhatsApp, Skype or Telegram video - a uniform in front of a police-station backdrop, sometimes a deepfaked face. You are told you are under 'digital custody': stay on camera, do not tell your family, keep your location on, sometimes even stay in a hotel. Then the demand: transfer your savings for 'RBI verification' into 'safe accounts'. Victims stay trapped for days, sometimes weeks - the Rajasthan case ran three months and 42 transfers. In Delhi, an elderly NRI doctor couple was drained of Rs. 14.85 crore in a fortnight.

- **Hang up the moment you hear 'digital arrest', 'custody' or 'verification transfer'.**
Nothing happens to you for disconnecting.
- Walk to a real police station with a family member if you want certainty. Real police exist in the physical world.
- Never stay on an unsolicited video call. Never share your location or isolation instructions with a caller.
- Tell one person immediately - family, neighbour, anyone. Isolation is the scam's oxygen.
- If money has moved, start the Part 6 protocol within the hour - speed decides whether it gets frozen.

The tell

There is no legal provision anywhere in India called a 'digital arrest'. Cyber officials repeat this constantly. No real agency conducts interrogation over video call, demands secrecy from your family, or asks you to move money to 'verify' it. If any of those three appear together, hang up.

SCAM 02**The fake courier and customs parcel call**

How it starts. Often the opening act of the digital arrest. An automated or human voice: 'Your FedEx parcel sent to [city abroad] contains illegal items; press 1 to speak to the narcotics department.' Some victims have actually shipped something recently, which makes the call feel personal. The 'narcotics officer' then escalates exactly like Scam 1. A newer variant involves a genuine-looking SMS from a courier name with a link to 'reschedule' a delivery that harvests your details.

- Hang up. Do not press 1. Do not call back the number shown in the SMS.
- Never open 'delivery problem' links; track parcels only inside the courier's official app or site.
- Report the number on Chakshu (sancharsaathi.gov.in) so it gets traced and cut off.

The tell

Couriers and customs never run criminal cases by phone, and India's customs authority sends notices in writing, with a document number you can verify on the government's own website. A crime 'in your name' announced by a phone call is always a script.

SCAM 03**Fake KYC, electricity and LPG 'last warning' messages**

How it starts. A scary SMS or call: 'Your bank KYC has expired, click this link within 24 hours or your account will be blocked.' Or in Hindi: 'Aapke bijli meter par case chal raha hai, aaj raat connection band hoga - is number par call karein.' Or: 'Your LPG subsidy is stuck, update your Aadhaar here.' The link opens a pixel-perfect copy of your bank's login page - that page is the whole scam. In the electricity variant, a frightened parent calls the number in the message and is talked through a 'reconnection payment' over UPI.

- Never log in through a link in a message. Open the bank's official app or type the website yourself.
- For bill threats, call only the number printed on your actual electricity bill.
- Report the message on Chakshu, and delete it. If a parent already paid, start Part 6.

The tell

Banks never suspend your account over a link sent by SMS, and electricity or LPG offices never warn of disconnection by random WhatsApp message or a phone call from a personal mobile number. Real disconnection notices come in writing, with an office you can walk into.

SCAM 04

UPI collect requests and swapped QR codes

How it starts. The scammer initiates a collect request for a refund or payment you are expecting - and while you check, they say 'just enter your PIN to receive it'. A phone screen that says 'Pay Rs. 24,999' is being described to you as 'receiving your refund'. The QR variant: you are selling something online, the 'buyer' sends a QR code to 'collect' their payment and asks you to scan it and enter a PIN. Another variant: an honest-looking shop counter's QR sticker is quietly replaced.

- Before entering any UPI PIN, read the screen out loud: does it say 'Pay'? To whom? How much?
- Decline any collect request you did not initiate, even mid-conversation.
- Merchants: check your counter QR sticker matches your account name, and re-check after any stranger leans over the counter.
- Enable your UPI app's screen lock, so a stolen phone is not an open wallet.

The tell

Receiving money in India never requires your PIN, OTP, or scanning anything. Ever. Anyone who says 'enter your PIN to receive' is standing between you and your own money.

SCAM 05

Fake customer-care numbers from search results and ads

How it starts. You Google 'bank name customer care number' or 'railway refund helpline'. The top result is a paid ad placed by a scam farm - or a lookalike site one letter off from the official one. The 'executive' sounds professional, 'diagnoses' your problem, and walks you into sharing an OTP or installing a 'support app'. The same trap exists for gas bookings, flight refunds, insurance and YouTube 'monetisation help'.

- Call only the number on the back of your card, or inside the official app - never from a search ad.
- Type the website yourself; check the domain letter by letter before logging in anywhere.
- Report the fake number on Chakshu; report the fake site on cybercrime.gov.in's 'Report Suspect'.

The tell

Banks print their real numbers on the back of your card and inside their official app - not in ads. A helpline that asks for your OTP, your card details, or an app install is not support, it is the scam itself.

SCAM 06

Task jobs on Telegram and YouTube - the trap for students

How it starts. A WhatsApp or Telegram message offers a part-time job: 'like YouTube videos, Rs. 50 per like, Rs. 3,000-5,000 per day.' The first few tasks genuinely pay - small amounts land in your account, screenshots go in the group. Then come 'prepaid tasks' or 'merchant orders': pay Rs. 5,000, get Rs. 6,500 back. You pay, you 'earn'. Then a 'combined task' of Rs. 50,000. Then you make a 'mistake', and are told to pay a penalty to unlock all your money. The group cheers you on. It is all theatre.

- Stop the moment any 'job' asks for a deposit, however small the first payout was.
- Leave every group that mixes tasks with payments, and report the numbers on 1930 or Chakshu.
- Warn the young people in your house by name - this scam specifically hunts students and first-time earners.

The tell

No real job requires you to pay money to earn money. The early payouts are bait, the 'mistake' is scripted, and the cheerleaders in the group are fake accounts.

SCAM 07

Trading apps, tip groups and the 'uncle' who is a stranger

How it starts. A well-dressed 'professor' or a friendly stranger adds you to a WhatsApp group that looks like a serious stock or crypto class. Members post daily profit screenshots. An 'analyst' gives tips that win. You are moved to a slick app or website and deposit real money - the numbers on screen grow beautifully. Withdrawals are 'processing'. Then one day the app asks a 'tax' to release your funds, or simply vanishes. Romance-driven variants run for months: a warm 'uncle' or a charming partner you have never met builds the same funnel.

- Invest only through apps of SEBI-registered brokers; verify the broker's registration before your first rupee.
- Leave any group with 'guaranteed' daily or weekly returns, however convincing the screenshots.
- Never send 'taxes' or 'fees' to withdraw your own money - that request IS the second scam.
- If you have already deposited, do not add more 'to unlock' - start Part 6 today.

The tell

Guaranteed returns that never dip are the tell - real markets don't do that. A stranger who discusses investments with you before knowing your birthday is running a portfolio, not a friendship. And no Indian regulator ever collects 'withdrawal tax' in advance.

SCAM 08

Loan app harassment

How it starts. An app promises instant loans without paperwork - and asks for access to your contacts, photos and call logs to 'verify' you. The loan is small, the tenure absurd (7-15 days), the interest criminal. When you can't repay on their clock, your photos are morphed, your entire contact list receives abusive messages calling you a fraudster, and the threats escalate to your family. Many of these apps are not lenders at all - they harvest data and shame victims into paying money they never received.

- Grant no app access to contacts, gallery or messages. Deny and uninstall.
- Borrow only from banks and RBI-registered NBFCs. Check the RBI Alert List before installing any loan app.
- If harassment has started: do not pay the blackmail, save every screenshot, and file on cybercrime.gov.in - this is a criminal offence by them, not you.
- Tell your family before the scammer does; shame only works in silence.

The tell

A genuine lender is RBI-registered, shows its licence, never needs your photo gallery, and never contacts your relatives for repayment. The RBI publishes an 'Alert List' of unauthorised digital lending platforms - if an app needs your contacts to give you money, it plans to use them.

SCAM 09

SIM swap and the 'network upgrade' call

How it starts. Your phone suddenly shows 'No Service' - sometimes after a call asking you to press some digits for a 'SIM upgrade' or 'eKYC'. What happened: the fraudster, armed with your personal details harvested from earlier leaks, convinced your operator to issue your number on a new SIM. Now every OTP meant for you - bank login, UPI, wallet resets - arrives on their phone. Often the first you learn of it is when your bank balance is gone.

- Act within minutes: call your operator from another phone, report the loss of service, and ask them to block the ported SIM.
- Call your bank and freeze cards and UPI; change passwords on the email linked to your accounts.
- Prevention: check TAFcop on sancharsaathi.gov.in for SIMs in your name, and enable SIM security in your phone's settings.
- Do the same for your parents' numbers - retirees are prime targets.

The tell

No telecom operator upgrades your SIM by asking you to press a code over a call. If your number goes dead without reason - especially with the SIM still in your hand - treat it as a bank emergency, not a network glitch.

SCAM 10**Screen-share and APK 'support' downloads**

How it starts. 'Our refund team needs to see your screen - install this quick app.' The app is a remote-control tool, or an APK file sent on WhatsApp that isn't on any app store. Once it runs, the 'executive' watches everything: your UPI PIN as you type it, the OTP on your screen, your bank balance. Variants arrive as 'KYC verification' APKs, 'reward claim' apps and 'refund assistant' software.

- Never install APK files from links or chats. If one was installed, uninstall it and change your banking passwords immediately.
- End any session where someone asked to 'see your screen to help you'.
- After any remote-session incident, treat every password as burned - change them all.

The tell

No bank, courier, or government body sends Android installation files over chat, and no genuine support needs to watch your screen. An app that is not on the Play Store or App Store, sent by a caller, is a burglary tool.

SCAM 11**The 'accidental' transfer that makes you the criminal**

How it starts. A stranger's money lands in your account - Rs. 15,000, maybe Rs. 50,000. They call in a panic: 'Please return it, my child's school fees.' You send it back to the number that called. Weeks later, the police are at your door - because that money was stolen from a fraud victim, and you have just become a link in the laundering chain, paid a small cut or simply used as a pass-through.

- Do not send the money anywhere - not back to the caller, not onward, nowhere. Leave it untouched.
- Inform your bank in writing and file a report on cybercrime.gov.in the same day.
- Never lend your account, UPI or card 'for a day' to anyone - including friends of friends offering a commission.

The tell

Money you cannot explain is not a windfall or an inconvenience - it is evidence. Returning it to a caller's instructions is how ordinary people get turned into money mules.

SCAM 12

Matrimonial and romance investment fraud

How it starts. A well-settled 'NRI engineer' matches on a matrimonial site or reaches out on LinkedIn. Weeks of warm, patient conversation. A video call - decent quality, plausible accent. Then, gently: 'I've been trading on this platform, you should try it with a small amount.' Or: 'Send a little help for the visa paperwork, I'll repay when I land.' The platform is fake, the visa never comes, and months of affection turn out to be a work rota run from a scam compound abroad - investigators have found many such operations are staffed by trafficked Indians.

- Never send money, OTPs, gift cards or crypto to anyone you have not met in person - whatever the relationship feels like.
- Reverse-image-search their photos; ask for a live, spontaneous video call and watch for excuses.
- Bring one family member into the story - romance scams survive only in secrecy.
- If it has already cost money: report it on cybercrime.gov.in without embarrassment; thousands of educated Indians file exactly this report every month.

The tell

A partner you have never met in person who steers conversations toward money - investments, fees, emergencies - is a script with a salary. The deeper the patience, the bigger the eventual ask.

PART 4

The universal red-flag checklist

One page. If any single item is present, stop and verify before anything else moves.

- 1 **Urgency.** 'Decide in 30 minutes or lose everything.' Real deadlines survive a night's sleep.
- 2 **Secrecy.** 'Do not tell your family or a lawyer.' No genuine legal or banking process is secret from your own family.
- 3 **Authority without paperwork.** Verbal threats, no written notice with a number you can verify on an official website.
- 4 **Unusual payment rails.** UPI to a stranger, an 'RBI safe account', gift cards, or crypto to fix a 'case'.
- 5 **A request for your OTP, PIN or password.** No bank, officer or company will ever ask. This line has no exceptions.
- 6 **A continuous video call.** Any 'process' that requires you to stay on camera is a holding pen, not a procedure.
- 7 **A download you did not seek.** APK files and 'support apps' from callers are remote-control tools.
- 8 **Guaranteed profit.** Returns that never dip, or a job that pays thousands for likes.
- 9 **Pay-first promises.** Any prize, refund, job or withdrawal that needs you to pay a fee first.

10 Contact details you did not verify. Numbers from ads, search results or messages - instead of your card, your bill, or the official app.

The family test

Before any money moves, ask two questions out loud: 'Would this request survive a 10-minute pause?' and 'Have I verified the asker through a channel I chose myself?' If either answer is no, it is a scam. Print this page if nothing else.

PART 5

The 45-minute Family Shield setup

Free, official settings from UIDAI, DoT, TRAI and your bank. Do this tonight; do it again on your parents' phones this weekend.

A. Phone and SIM - 10 minutes.

- Dial ***#06#** on every family phone and note the 15-digit IMEI somewhere safe (not on the phone itself). If a phone is ever stolen, this is what blocks it nationwide.
- Open **sancharsaathi.gov.in** (or the official Sanchar Saathi app) and run '**Know Your Mobile Connections**' (**TAF COP**): enter the mobile number, verify with OTP, and see every SIM issued in your name. Flag any number you do not recognise as 'Not my number' - the operator must investigate and disconnect it. It is free; anyone charging you for this is a scammer.
- Register on **Do Not Disturb**: send the SMS **START 0** to **1909**, or call 1909 and choose the fully-blocked option. This kills most promotional calls and messages - which is how most scams first reach your family.
- Save **1930** (National Cyber Crime Helpline) in every family phone, saved as 'CYBER HELPLINE'. Report suspicious calls and SMS on **Chakshu** at sancharsaathi.gov.in - reporting within the last 30 days is accepted, and every report helps trace and cut off fraud numbers.

B. Aadhaar - 5 minutes.

- Lock your Aadhaar biometrics: open **myaadhaar.uidai.gov.in** or the **mAadhaar** app, and enable **Biometric Lock** (your mobile number must be registered with UIDAI). Once locked, no one can authenticate with your fingerprints or iris - any attempt returns error code 330.
- For full protection, lock the Aadhaar number itself (UID lock). You first need a 16-digit Virtual ID (VID): SMS **GVID** to **1947**. Then lock the UID on the same website. To unlock later, SMS **RVID** to 1947 to retrieve your VID first.
- Do this for every adult in the house. Banks and SIMs can use Aadhaar OTP authentication even when biometrics are locked - so also set a daily limit awareness on Aadhaar-linked accounts.

C. Banking and UPI - 10 minutes.

- Set **per-day UPI limits** inside each payment app to match your real needs - a limit of Rs. 5,000-10,000 per transaction is enough for most families, and it caps the damage of any single hijacked session.
- In your bank app's card controls, **disable international and online transactions** on cards you do not actively use online; switch them on only when needed.
- Turn on **SMS and email alerts** for every transaction, on every account, for every family member.
- Write down your bank's **official fraud helpline** from the back of your card - and teach the family that this is the only bank number we ever call.
- Enable your UPI app's **app lock** so it needs your phone's fingerprint or PIN before opening.

D. WhatsApp and messaging - 5 minutes.

- In WhatsApp settings, enable **silence for unknown callers** and set privacy to 'My contacts'. Block and report spam instead of replying.
- Agree as a family: no one acts on any 'forwarded many times' money message, and everyone leaves 'investment tip' groups.
- Any 'bank' message on WhatsApp is suspect - banks in India do not send you WhatsApp requests to move money.

E. Search and download habits - 5 minutes.

- Never call a helpline number from a search ad. For anything official, type the website yourself or use the app.
- Never install apps from APK files or links - only from the Play Store or App Store.
- Before logging in anywhere, read the domain letter by letter.

F. The family code word - 5 minutes.

Choose one word that only your family knows. Any call claiming an emergency - a son in hospital, a daughter's phone lost, a parent in trouble - must include the code word before anyone moves money or shares anything. Scammers mine names and relationships from social media; they cannot mine a word that was never written down. Pair it with the **Verify-then-Pay rule**: any payment above your family threshold (Rs. 5,000 is a good start) waits 10 minutes and survives one verification call to a number you already had.

PART 6

If it happens: the first 60 minutes

Money stolen by fraud can often be frozen - if you move faster than the fraudster moves it. Here is the exact sequence.

- 1 **Minute 0-5: Stop the bleeding.** Hang up. Do not pay 'one last verification fee' - it funds nothing but the scam. If someone is still on a video call 'supervising' you, walk out of the room and tell one person. You are not in trouble; you are mid-crime, and the crime ends the moment you disconnect.
- 2 **Minute 5-10: Call 1930.** The National Cyber Crime Helpline is run by your State's police. Give them the transaction details - amount, time, your bank, where the money went. You will receive an SMS with a **14-digit acknowledgement number starting with '3'**. This feeds the Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS), which can push hold notices to banks within minutes.
- 3 **Minute 10-20: File on cybercrime.gov.in.** Open 'Report Other Cyber Crime' and choose the Online Financial Fraud category. Register with your mobile (OTP valid 30 minutes), then complete the complaint using your acknowledgement number. Upload screenshots of transactions, chats and the caller's number. Portal-filed complaints get an acknowledgement starting with '2'.
- 4 **Same window: Call your bank's official number.** Freeze cards, block UPI, and lodge the bank's own complaint - get its complaint ID. This is not instead of 1930; both run in parallel. Your reporting clock is what RBI liability rules measure.
- 5 **Minute 20-40: Preserve the evidence.** Transaction IDs (UTR), the account numbers the money went to, phone numbers, the app names, chat exports, the caller's claimed name and 'badge number'. Do not delete anything, including the scam group.
- 6 **Minute 40-60: Register the FIR.** Go to the police station with the acknowledgement numbers, or use the e-Zero FIR mechanism where your State has operationalised it. The Supreme Court's August 2026 directions are pushing every State to make this smooth - a refusal to register can be escalated to the State's cybercrime coordination centre.

What happens after you report. Under the MHA's January 2026 SOP, CFCFRMS issues notices to the banks holding the reported amounts (under Section 168 BNSS read with Section 94 BNSS) and follows the money across accounts until the trail is held. A Money Restoration Mechanism now spans 57 banks and all States and Union Territories, and a Grievance Redressal Mechanism covers over 1.23 lakh bank branches across 69 banks, with grievance officers expected to respond within seven days. None of this replaces your own follow-up: track your complaint on the portal and keep the acknowledgement, the bank complaint ID and every document in one folder.

If the fraud involves your phone or SIM, add two steps: get a duplicate SIM from your operator (note that SMS re-activates only 24 hours after the new SIM is activated, per TRAI rules), then block the stolen handset by IMEI on Sanchar Saathi's 'Block Lost/Stolen Mobile' (CEIR) with the FIR copy and an ID proof - the phone goes dead on every network in India within about 24 hours.

The golden hour

The first minutes decide everything. Fraud money typically moves through 2-3 mule accounts within the hour. 1930 plus the portal plus your bank, all inside the first hour, is the single strongest predictor of recovery.

PART 7

Who pays when fraud happens? The RBI rules

India's banking rules decide liability based on whose fault it was and how fast you reported. Learn this before you need it.

The Reserve Bank's 2026 directions on fraudulent electronic banking transactions (the Responsible Business Conduct framework, amended June 2026) set the liability ladder below. Two points help every victim: the **burden of proving customer liability lies on the bank, not on you**, and a transaction you approved **under coercion or duress** - the exact situation in a digital arrest - is itself defined as a fraudulent transaction. Say so, in writing, in your complaint.

What happened	Your liability under RBI rules
The bank's system or staff negligence caused it	Zero - reversal is due whether or not you reported it
Third-party breach (not your fault, not the bank's)	Zero if you report to the bank within 5 calendar days of the transaction
Third-party breach, reported later than 5 days	As per the bank's board-approved policy
You shared your PIN/OTP (customer negligence)	You bear losses until you report it; everything after your report is the bank's
You approved the payment under coercion (digital arrest)	Counts as a 'fraudulent EBT' - report it as coercion in writing and claim accordingly

- Banks must respond to your fraud complaint within **45 calendar days** for domestic frauds (60 for cross-border) - with reversal details if you qualify for zero liability.
- For credit-card frauds, banks must give a **shadow reversal within 5 calendar days** of your notification while they investigate.
- Banks are required to tell customers to report fraud via the portal or 1930 'at the earliest' - the longer you wait, the weaker your position.
- Banks can waive liability at their discretion - always ask.

If the bank rejects or stalls: complain in writing and keep the receipt; escalate to the bank's Principal Nodal Officer; if 30 days pass without resolution or you are unsatisfied, file with the **RBI Integrated Ombudsman at cms.rbi.org.in** - free, online, and it works. Keep your 1930/portal acknowledgement, the bank complaint ID and the transaction records together; the Ombudsman reads paperwork.

PART 8

The Family Shield plan

Devices and accounts can be hardened in one evening. A family has to practice, out loud, before the phone rings.

The two family rules. 1) **Verify-then-Pay:** above your threshold, every payment waits 10 minutes and survives one verification call made by you - never by the number that just called you. 2) **The code word:** any emergency call without the code word is a scam, full stop - no exceptions for tears, urgency or 'confidentiality'.

The monthly 10-minute audit. Put it on the family calendar - the first Sunday of every month:

- Run TAF COP on sancharsaathi.gov.in for each adult's number - any SIM that isn't ours gets flagged.
- Check the family phones: WhatsApp unknown-caller silence still on, no new 'investment' or 'job' groups, no unknown apps.
- Confirm bank SMS alerts still arrive on the right numbers; note anything odd in the month's statements.
- Ask each other - especially the elders - one question: 'What scary or exciting calls did you get this month?' Shame keeps victims silent; curiosity keeps them talking.
- Verify the Emergency Action Card (Part 9) is still on the fridge and 1930 is still saved on every phone.

How to talk to parents who won't listen. You cannot out-stubborn a parent with warnings - stories work better. Use the real cases from Part 1: 'An 81-year-old businessman in Belagavi lost Rs. 15 crore because the caller sounded exactly like a real CBI officer.' Then set the rules together, with them, not for them - people defend rules they helped write. Three sentences worth rehearsing together:

- 'If anyone calls about a parcel, a case, or your KYC - hang up and call me. Real police never take money.'
- 'No one from a bank ever asks for an OTP - not once, not for any reason. If they do, it's a scam.'
- 'If a call scares you or excites you, we wait one hour before doing anything. Nothing real breaks in one hour.'

What kids need to know: never share OTPs even with friends; never install games or 'free skin' apps from links; any online 'friend' who sends money and asks for some back is running a laundering trap.

If a family member is mid-scam right now: get physically next to them, ask them to hang up, and call 1930 together. Do not shame them mid-rescue - the Supreme Court's own observations note that victim shaming is why so many cases go unreported. The scam's spell breaks when the isolation does.

PART 9

The Emergency Action Card

Print this page or photograph it. Keep it where the whole family can see it.

CALL IMMEDIATELY IF MONEY IS GONE	
	National Cyber Crime Helpline (call first)
	Report online fraud - 'Report Other Cyber Crime'
	TAF COP (SIMs in your name), CEIR (block lost phone), Chakshu (report fraud calls)
	Lock Aadhaar biometrics
	RBI Ombudsman - escalate if the bank stalls 30 days
	Do Not Disturb registration (SMS: START 0)
YOUR NUMBERS	

The three lines that stop almost everything

No PIN to receive money. No OTP to anyone, ever. No payment without the code word.

This handbook is awareness guidance, not legal advice. Helplines and processes can change - the official portals listed above always carry the current version.

APPENDIX

Sources and verification

Every fact in this handbook was verified against these official or primary sources as of 24 September 2026.

- Reserve Bank of India - (Commercial Banks - Responsible Business Conduct) Third Amendment Directions, 24 June 2026: liability rules for fraudulent electronic banking transactions (zero-liability conditions, 5-calendar-day reporting window, 45-day response timeline, coercion/duress definition, burden of proof).
- Ministry of Home Affairs - Standard Operating Procedure for the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP) and CFCFRMS, 2 January 2026: 1930 helpline process, acknowledgement numbers, bank hold notices under Section 168 BNSS read with Section 94 BNSS.
- cybercrime.gov.in - citizen manual and Suspect Repository facility.
- Sanchar Saathi portal, Department of Telecommunications - CEIR (block lost/stolen handsets), TAF COP (connections in your name), Chakshu (report fraud communications).
- UIDAI - Aadhaar Lock/Unlock and Biometric Lock services (myaadhaar.uidai.gov.in, mAadhaar app, SMS to 1947).
- TRAI - Customer Preference Registration (DND) via 1909.

- Hindustan Times, 29 July 2026 - cyber-fraud losses of Rs. 22,845.73 crore in 2024 tabled in Parliament; digital-arrest case records.
- The Hindu, 5 September 2026 - CBI Operation Chakra-VI and the Supreme Court's continuing oversight.
- Supreme Court interim orders, August 2026 - I4C status report figures (complaints, restoration mechanism coverage).
- BBC News, September 2025 - Gurugram digital-arrest victim's account.
- Newsbytes / News18, July 2026 - digital-arrest complaint and loss data 2022-2026.
- NITI Aayog - 'Digital Arrest: The Modern-Day Cyber Scam' explainer.

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